a viewing balcony for public audiences, private and public audience halls and elaborate office buildings. In this way, Mughal court ritual could be seamlessly enacted even far away from its capital at Lahore. Catherine Asher calls it ‘the first structure to introduce the courtly Mughal style of architecture to eastern India’. At the time, local zamindars only had crudely constructed rudimentary forts to show so the visual reminder of the might and wealth of the Mughal Empire was silently but eloquently expressed. A large stone slab at the entrance of the palace gates bears two inscriptions that show that the raja was quite aware of his dual role. One inscription, in Persian, is addressed to the emperor, Sultan Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar Badshah Ghazi, and mentions the raja only very briefly, stating rather blandly that he ‘has built a strong building’. The longer Sanskrit inscription on the same slab does not mention Akbar at all and instead celebrates the raja as head of the Kachhwaha Rajputs and refers to him, with fulsome celebration, as Sri Maharajadhiraja Maharaja (king of kings). Today, sadly, the Rohtas Fort and all Raja Man Singh’s ambitious buildings lie in a state of ruined neglect.

As has been noted, after the magnificent creative explosion of Fatehpur Sikri, Akbar would never again commission buildings on the same scale. From now on, it would be his amirs and mansabdars who would take on the job of translating Mughal splendour into stone in the distant hinterlands of the empire. It was these favoured courtiers who carried imperial aesthetics and culture into dusty desert towns and swampy outposts, negotiating local traditions both Hindu and Muslim. And it would be Raja Man Singh, brought up at the Mughal court since he was twelve years old, who would carry out this work with the most panache and audacity.

While Man Singh’s career would outstrip the others, there were many other Rajput rajas and chieftains who would now travel throughout the empire as Mughal mansabdars and remain for months and even years away from their home towns. Sometimes the rajas appointed Jains or Brahmins to administer to their states in their absence, since ‘Rajput rulers realised the pitfalls of leaving the governance of their kingdoms in the hands of close male relatives during their own absence’. But often, as noted by historians Rima Hooja and Varsha Joshi, it was the most senior rani who carried out the work of governing the kingdom in the absence of her husband. In the case of Raja Man Singh, it was his chief Bhattiyani rani, Kanakwati, who ruled his thikana and controlled the state’s finances. In Bikaner, Rani Ganga